

How the participation intensity measure works

The early childhood education (ECE) participation intensity measure looks at the average weekly hours each child spends in ECE, then reports on the percentage of children who attended:

- 10 hours or more on average per week
- 20 hours or more on average per week

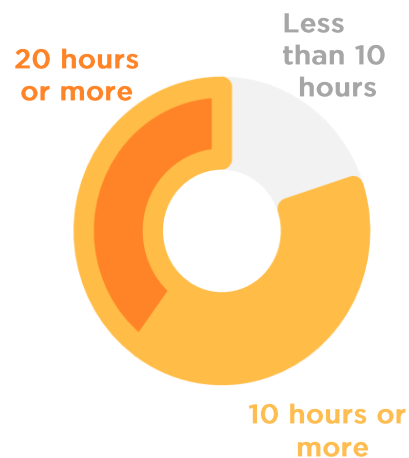
These two levels of participation intensity are measured and reported separately for 3-year-olds and 4-year-olds, which means there is a total of four categories for participation intensity.¹ Their participation is recorded across the 52 weeks they were aged 3 or 4.

The denominator in this measure is the total number of children aged 3 or 4 in New Zealand.²

The intensity levels can be seen in the ring chart below. The whole ring includes all children in New Zealand aged 3 or 4, categorised by the average weekly hours spent in ECE.

In this chart:

- Children participating on average less than 10 hours a week (the grey piece of the ring) are not included in either of the intensity levels we report on. This includes children not attending ECE at all.
- Children participating 10 hours or more per week (the yellow piece of the ring) are counted in the *10 hours or more* intensity level.
- Children participating 20 hours or more per week (the orange piece of the ring) make up the *20 hours or more* intensity level.
- Children in the *20 hours or more* group are a subset of the *10 hours or more* group.



Participation intensity in 2025

83.4%

of children aged 4 attended ECE for an average of **10 hours or more** per week.

76.9%

of children aged 3 attended ECE for an average of **10 hours or more** per week.

43.4%

of children aged 4 attended ECE for an average of **20 hours or more** per week.

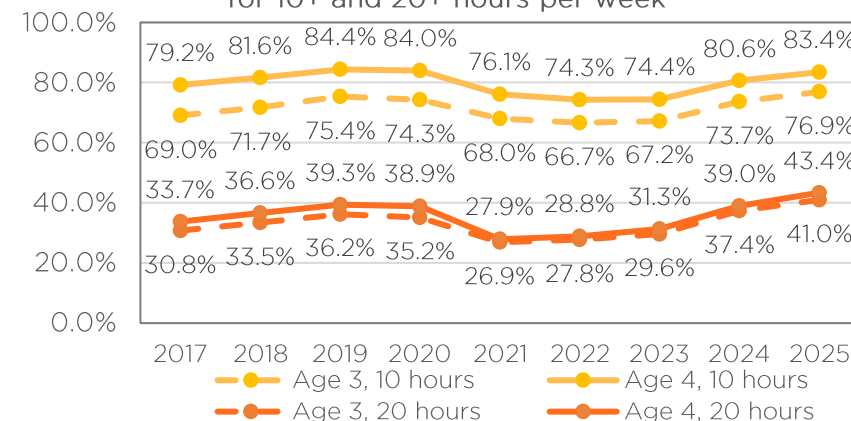
41.0%

of children aged 3 attended ECE for an average of **20 hours or more** per week.

Trends over time

Between 2024 and 2025, the proportion of children reaching both levels of average weekly participation increased for both 3-year-olds and 4-year-olds.

Proportion of 3 & 4 year olds participating in ECE for 10+ and 20+ hours per week



The proportion of children participating across all four categories decreased after 2020 due to the impacts of COVID-19. Because of how the intensity measurements are constructed, COVID-19 lockdowns appear in multiple reporting years. The national lockdown in 2020 and 2021 affected participation intensity rates, as did the regional and Auckland lockdowns.

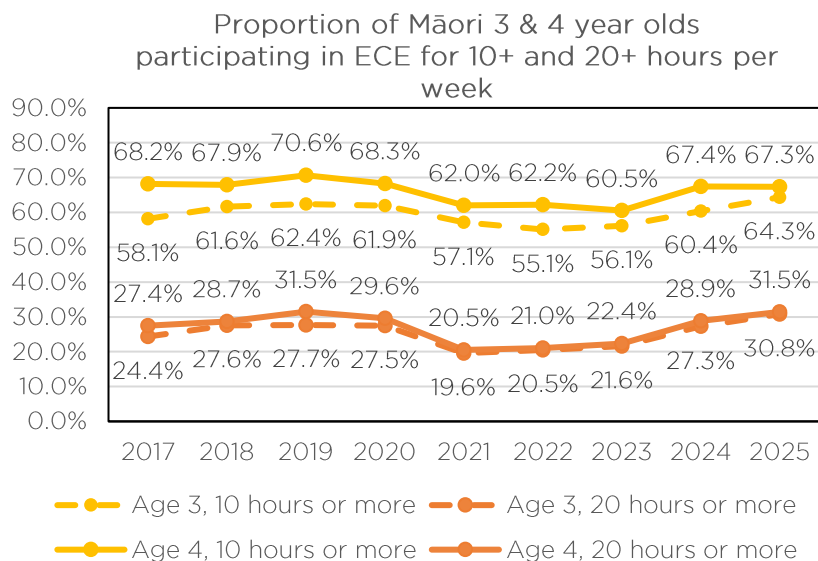
The proportion of children participating 20 hours or more first surpassed 2020 (pre-COVID) rates for both 3 and 4 year olds in 2024. This upward trend continued in 2025. Additionally, in 2025, the proportion of 3-year-olds attending 10 hours or more also exceeded the 2020 level.

In 2025, for 4-year-olds, the proportion of children participating for 10 hours or more has not returned the 2020 rates, but is approaching this rate.

Mokopuna Māori

Between 2024 and 2025, for mokopuna Māori aged 3 both categories of participation intensity increased.

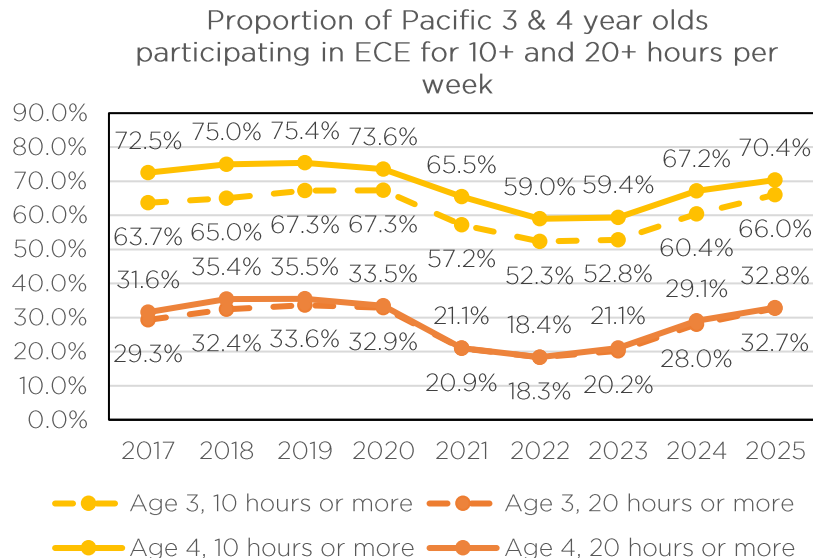
Among those aged 4, the 20 hours or more category also increased. However, the 10 hours or more category remained virtually unchanged, with a slight decrease of 0.1 percentage points.



During the COVID-19 pandemic, all four categories had a decrease in the proportion of mokopuna Māori participating. However, by 2025, participation for mokopuna Māori surpassed 2020 (pre-COVID) levels for the first time, with the exception of the aged 4 10 hours or more category.

Pacific children

Between 2024 and 2025, all four participation intensity categories increased for Pacific children.

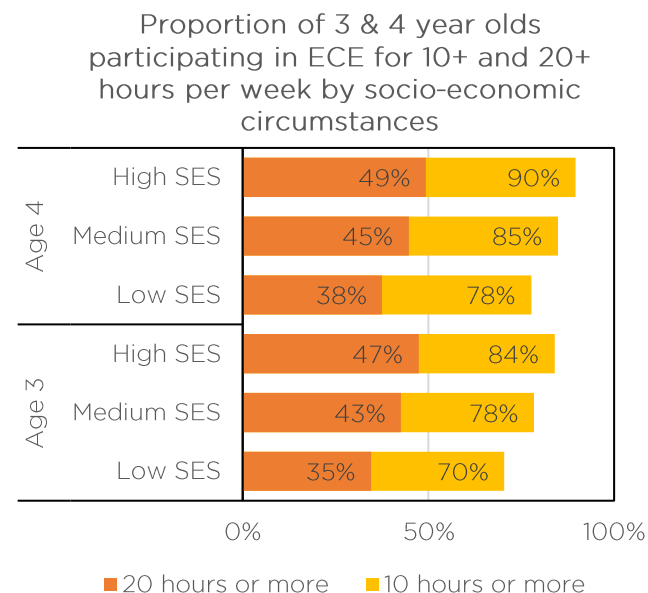


Participation for Pacific children fell sharply during the COVID-19 pandemic. This decline in participation intensity was likely due to the high concentration of Pacific children in Auckland, which experienced the greatest impact from COVID-19 lockdowns and other restrictions.

By 2025, each of the four participation intensity categories had almost reached 2020 rates for Pacific children. The recovery was greatest for the 20 hours or more categories. For Pacific children aged 3, participation intensity was 32.9% in 2020 and reached 32.7% in 2025. For Pacific children aged 4, it was 33.5% in 2020 and reached 32.8% in 2025.

Socio-economic circumstances

The chart below shows how children's participation intensity varies by the socio-economic circumstances (SES) of communities where they live. Here, socio-economic circumstances are broken down into low, medium, and high SES, which is based on NZ Deprivation Index scores.³



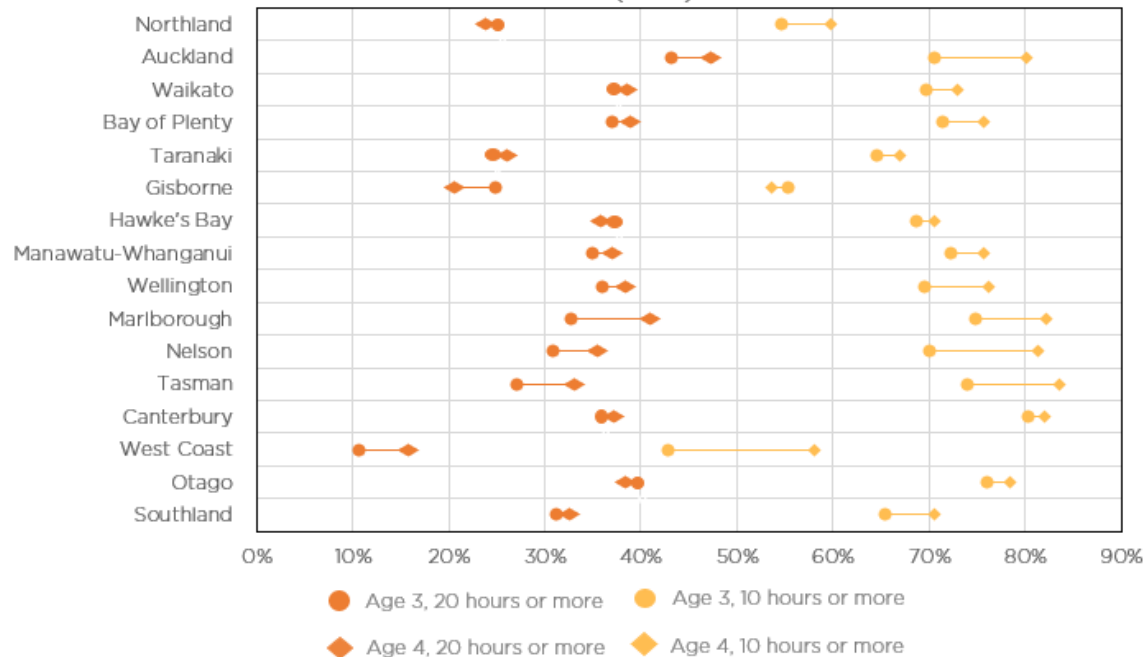
In 2025, for both age 3 and age 4 groups, children living in low socio-economic areas had lower participation intensity than those in high socio-economic areas. This has been a persistent pattern over time.

3. NZ Deprivation Index scores have been grouped into three categories: high socio-economic status (scores 1 to 3), medium (scores 4 to 7) and low (scores 8 to 10).

Regional council

In the chart below, the proportion of 3-year-olds and 4-year-olds attending 10 hours or more and 20 hours or more are shown for each regional council in 2025.

Percentage of Children Reaching Participation Intensity levels by Regional Council (2025)



The Canterbury region had the highest proportion of 3-year-olds attending 10 hours or more, at 80.3%. The Auckland region had the highest proportion of 3-year-olds attending 20 hours or more, at 43.2%.

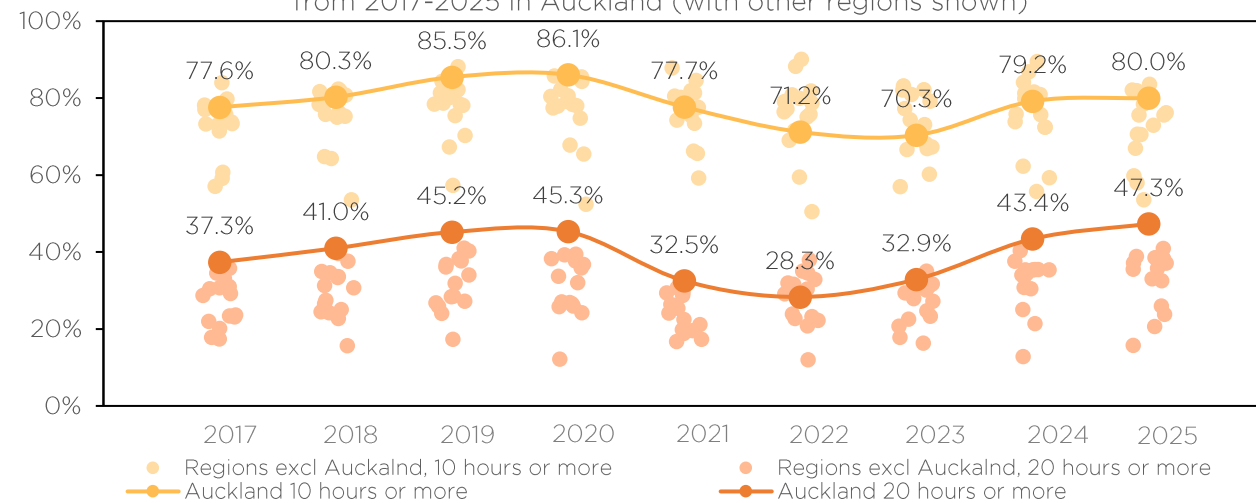
For 4-year-olds, the Tasman region had the highest proportion attending 10 hours or more, at 83.6%. The Auckland region had the highest proportion attending 20 hours or more, at 47.3%.

Regional spotlight: Auckland Regional Council

In the graph below, participation intensity is examined over time for Auckland region. The proportion of 4-year-olds attending 10 hours or more and 20 hours or more is shown each year for the Auckland region (darker dots) and other regions (lighter dots).

The graph shows that in 2025, Auckland sits in the middle to upper range for the 10 hours or more category and has the highest participation intensity for 20 hours or more.

Percentage of 4-year-olds attending 10 hours + and 20 hours + per week from 2017-2025 in Auckland (with other regions shown)



Due to the impacts of COVID-19, participation intensity decreased nationwide after 2020, but Auckland experienced a steeper drop and a slower recovery than other regions, likely due to the impacts of extended lockdowns and other restrictions.

Among 4-year-olds in the Auckland region, participation intensity fell in 2021 and 2022. The proportion attending 10 hours or more dropped from 86.1% in 2020 to 71.2% in 2022, while those attending 20 hours or more declined from 45.3% to 28.3%.

By 2025, while The proportion of Auckland children participating 10 hours or more remains slightly below the rates of 2020, participation in the 20 hours or more categories has already surpassed the 2020 rate.

